



Ezgi Başaran. *The New Spirit of Islamism: Interactions between the AKP, Ennahda and the Muslim Brotherhood*. London: I.B. Tauris - Bloomsbury. 2024. 256 pp. ISBN 978-07-5565-295-2. £15.39.

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Ezgi Başaran's *The New Spirit of Islamism: Interactions between the AKP, Ennahda, and the Muslim Brotherhood* offers a rigorous and timely analysis of how three major Islamist movements—the AKP in Turkey, Tunisia's Ennahda, and Egypt's Muslim Brotherhood—have interacted and learned from one another, particularly after the 2011 revolutions. A journalist-turned-academic at the University of Oxford and coordinator of its Programme on Contemporary Turkey, Başaran combines scholarly rigor with deep regional insight in a field often confined to single-country analyses.

Drawing on Social Movement Studies, she shows that analyzing these interactions provides a richer understanding of Islamist agency and adaptability. The book's central thesis identifies a diffusion of tactics among the AKP, Ennahda, and the Muslim Brotherhood, showing how these parties redefined their ambitions in response to new political and economic pressures. This perspective moves beyond ideological essentialism, portraying Islamism as a pragmatic and evolving project shaped by crises, governance experiences, and the imperatives of neoliberal modernity. As Başaran notes, «the pursuit of success» (p. 122) has supplanted legitimacy as the core logic of contemporary Islamist politics, particularly in semi-democratic contexts. By situating Islamist movements within global networks of power and exchange, Başaran demonstrates how they can cooperate with secular forces and prioritize short-term political and economic objectives while remaining shaped by Islamic ethical frameworks.

Chapter 1 develops a comprehensive and critical literature review, mapping how post-Cold War political science has shaped the conceptual vocabulary used to theorize Islamism. Başaran argues that, following 9/11 and the 2011 revolutions, Islamist parties were compelled to “modernize” their ideological, political, and economic frameworks. This transformation does not equate to Western secularization but rather represents an adaptation of Islamist praxis to a globalized, neoliberal context. Islamists, she argues, are no longer defined primarily by resistance or authoritarianism; they now operate within a global system that actively reshapes their discourses and strategies. From this perspective emerges what she terms «a new spirit of Islamism» characterized as an «endeavor to integrate Islamist praxis into the framework of neoliberal rationality» (p. 12). Although some critiques remain broad in scope, Başaran consistently grounds her arguments in empirical material and details her methodology, which combines face-to-face interviews with analysis of official documents. Her analytical categories thus emerge inductively from the data rather than being imposed by preexisting theoretical frameworks.

Chapter 2 traces the ideological genealogy of contemporary Islamist movements,

from Hasan al-Banna [Ḥasan al-Bannā] and Sayyid Qutb [Sayyid Quṭb] to their later developments across Turkey, Tunisia, and Egypt. Başaran challenges postmodern interpretations that reduce Islamism to a search for cultural authenticity. Instead, she argues that it constitutes a political project deeply shaped by 20th-century Western political and intellectual currents, ranging from liberalism to totalitarianism. This approach undermines the notion of Islamism as a monolithic ideology. She contextualizes the rise of Islamist movements within the legacies of colonialism, nation-building, Cold War alignments, and the neoliberal turn of the 1990s. She further demonstrates how globalization and the expansion of digital communication have transformed Islamist identities, forging a symbolic sense of global Muslim solidarity activated during crises. Her comparative analysis illuminates the distinct yet interconnected trajectories of Turkey's AKP, Egypt's Muslim Brotherhood, and Tunisia's Ennahda. She shows how the AKP emerged from the neoliberal turn within the Milli Görüş tradition and the rise of an Islamic bourgeoisie; how the Muslim Brotherhood shifted from confrontation to negotiation under Mubarak [Mubārak]; and how Ennahda, long suppressed under Ben Ali [Bin 'Alī], rebranded itself post-revolution as a moderate actor willing to set aside its demand for sharia.

In Chapter 3, Başaran maps the networked nature of these movements, revealing how they have learned from one another while adapting to local constraints. Notably, the author emphasizes the pivotal role of the AKP in shaping the development of Islamist ideologies from the late 1990s onward. Through the lens of diffusion, she traces the influence of key Islamist texts (al-Banna, Qutb, and others) in the 1960s and 1970s, as well as the impact of major international events. She argues that the Cold War facilitated the translation and circulation of Islamist writings between Arabic and Turkish—often supported by Turkish and Western intelligence services that viewed Islamist ideology as a useful counterweight to communism. She also highlights the impact of the Iranian Revolution and the First Intifada, which marked a shift from pan-Islamic narratives to nationally grounded Islamist ideologies. During this period, diffusion centered less on tactics or policy transfer than on the rhetoric of “success” appealing to populations disillusioned with politics yet attracted to emerging prospects of economic growth.

Chapter 4 reconstructs the history of relations among the three movements. Drawing on interviews with current and former high-ranking party officials as well as official documents and diplomatic events, Başaran maps the network of interlocutors that facilitated exchanges. Particularly striking is her analysis of brokers, including broadcasters such as Al-Jazeera, businessmen and intellectuals, who shaped both global influence and the tactics of diffusion through which the AKP, Muslim Brotherhood, and Ennahda shared expertise and know-how. Unlike the previous chapter, which focused on ideological diffusion, this chapter examines party-to-party relations, emphasizing meetings—formal or informal—designed to exchange political tactics rather than ideas.

The chapter also highlights the centrality of the AKP, which—unsurprisingly—emerges as the most influential actor, benefiting from greater operational freedom and the most consolidated republican-democratic framework among the three.

In Başaran’s analysis of Islamist mobilization strategies (Chapter 5), particularly in North Africa under authoritarian regimes, economic development and welfare provision emerge as crucial yet often underestimated dimensions of political action. Many of the diffusion processes she identifies revolve around welfare delivery and economic empowerment, functioning both as instruments of legitimacy and as expressions of moral governance. In this regard, the AKP’s rhetoric – circulated among its Islamist allies – emphasized the importance of municipal politics as a basis for building political power. At the municipal level, service networks and Islamist-organized welfare structures allowed parties to distribute resources more effectively than the region’s centralized, often corrupt parties. While Başaran acknowledges that economic issues are not the book’s primary focus, she skillfully integrates them into her analysis, linking material concerns to the cultural and moral frameworks through which Islamist actors articulate authority. These dynamics underscore the early importance attributed by emerging parties to economic achievement and neoliberal development within an Islamist perspective. In contexts where regimes appear deeply corrupt and democratically deficient, concepts such as the welfare state or individual economic success acquire strong political and ideological resonance, revitalizing Islamist movements and enhancing their broader appeal.

In Chapter 6, Başaran emphasizes how Islamists have long framed economic development as a moral duty tied to dignity, justice, and collective prosperity. Since the late twentieth century, leading Islamist movements have increasingly incorporated capitalist and neoliberal principles into their political agendas. Within this context, Başaran introduces the concept of the *homo islamicus*: «an entrepreneur who works hard for material gain and whose spiritual purity will be rewarded on earth through shared profits and social recognition» (p. 104). This figure exemplifies the AKP’s fusion of piety and productivity during the 2000s, when Erdoğan’s emphasis on growth, opportunity, and moral renewal generated broad societal support. As Başaran argues, the AKP’s “ethic of work” parallels Weber’s Protestant ethic, linking divine approval to discipline, industriousness, and market participation. Similar narratives, rooted in spiritual values yet oriented toward economic pragmatism, were subsequently adopted by Ennahda and the Muslim Brotherhood, both of which drew on an expanding Muslim middle class, whose aspirations for social mobility aligned with the demands of the 2011 revolutions. For Başaran, this evolution marks the rise of individualized notions of “success”, echoing Olivier Roy’s concept of “post-Islamist Islamization” (2004), in which Islamic references permeate everyday practices while no longer constituting a comprehensive political project. This analysis highlights how Islamist movements reconcile religious

ethics with economic rationality to sustain legitimacy and mobilize support in contemporary contexts.

In Başaran's reading, post-Islamism does not signal the end of political Islam but rather a substantial reconfiguration of its objectives. It reflects an ongoing effort to reconcile faith, individualism, and modernity, paralleling broader global transformations under neoliberal capitalism. The new spirit of Islamism, theorized in Chapter 7, explicitly engages with Boltanski and Chiapello's *The New Spirit of Capitalism*. Just as they describe capitalism's adaptation through a moral and managerial ideology, Islamist actors similarly internalize neoliberal rationality while embedding it within ethical and religious frameworks. Market success and entrepreneurial initiative are thus recast as morally sanctioned endeavors, aligning individual achievement with collective and spiritual responsibilities. These dynamics function both as a legitimizing mechanism and a practical strategy: by framing economic activity as ethically grounded, post-Islamist movements reconcile personal ambition with communal Islamic values, enhancing political credibility and social resonance. In this respect, the new spirit of Islamism mirrors the adaptive logic identified by Boltanski and Chiapello, providing an ethically inflected mode of governance and social engagement that renders neoliberal imperatives intelligible, motivating, and culturally coherent. Başaran's analysis demonstrates how contemporary Islamism navigates modernity, markets, and morality without relinquishing its religious foundations.

In Chapter 8, Başaran turns to the aftermath of 2013 to explain why all three movements—albeit to varying degrees—must be regarded as political failures. The Muslim Brotherhood and Ennahda were removed from power, while the AKP, although dominant, has come to epitomize global illiberalism. Crucially, Başaran highlights the AKP's leadership role and the strategic diffusion of its expertise to other Islamist organizations. Since 2013, Turkey has functioned as a hub for Egyptian Muslim Brotherhood networks, while simultaneously maintaining close ties to Ennahda. This support proved particularly vital when the Tunisian movement confronted governance inexperience and, upon returning to opposition, was marginalized by President Saïed [Sa'ïd]. The AKP's organizational competencies, institutional practices, and strategic experience thus enhanced the capacities of allied Islamist actors, enabling their adaptation to political and administrative pressures. As Başaran notes, «the complex relationship between Islamism and democracy remains an ongoing and evolving phenomenon, subject to contextual factors and the interplay of political forces» (p. 159). Her conclusion is sobering: despite their ideological distinctiveness, Islamist actors operate within the same global logics of competition, adaptation, and pragmatic pursuit of authority as other political movements, demonstrating that organizational experience is as decisive as ideology in shaping political outcomes.

Overall, *The New Spirit of Islamism* represents a conceptually and methodologi-

cally innovative contribution to the study of contemporary Islamism. By tracing interactions among the AKP, Ennahda, and the Muslim Brotherhood, Başaran provides a finely contextualized analysis of how Islamist actors adapted to the political, social, and economic challenges of the post-2011 era. The book challenges simplistic portrayals of Islamism as monolithic or purely ideological, revealing instead a dynamic field of actors engaged in learning, diffusion, and pragmatic transformation under globalization and neoliberal pressures.

Methodologically, the book employs a Grounded Theory (GT) approach, emphasizing actors' voices, complemented by analysis of official events and documents. This allows conceptual categories to emerge inductively, thereby departing from dominant Western frameworks and capturing otherwise invisible dynamics. Although the interviews mainly cover the years 2011–2013 and include relatively few prominent Egyptian figures, this limitation is mitigated by complementary qualitative sources that enrich and contextualize the analysis. Conceptually, Başaran links neoliberal rationality with Islamic political ethics, reframing the interaction of economy, faith, and legitimacy. The result is an empirically rich and theoretically sophisticated account of twenty-first-century Islamism.

References

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